Audencia BUSINESS SCHOOL

深圳南特金融科技学院
Shenzhen Audencia Financial Technology Institute



MSC FINANCIAL TECHNOLOGY & RISK CONTROL
THESIS GUIDELINES

Promo 2025

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WHAT IS A THESIS?

A thesis is the culmination of an in-depth analysis and research into a question related to a financial technology or risk control. Your thesis could be, but not limited to, the following areas: development of technologies in financial industry, application of financial technologies (e.g., AI, block chain, big data, and cloud computing) in other fields (e.g., business, charity, and environment-protection), management issues or marketing strategies of financial technology companies, technology-oriented transform or upgrade of traditional financial companies, theories or methods of risk control, application of risk control in practice, management issues related to risk control, quantitative investment analysis, portfolio analysis, identification of risk type of credit card holders, etc.

Your thesis is expected to make theoretical, methodological or managerial contribution to related prior work. Specifically, the thesis measures your ability to:

- Synthesize journal articles and scholarly reference works related to the topic selected.
- Formulate a research question based on your review of the literature.
- Design a method for collecting empirical data to answer your research question including selecting appropriate cases/sources/participants from which you will gather data.
- Analyze and draw conclusions from your data collection.
- Formulate recommendations to the relevant stakeholders of your research based on your results.
- Identify the limitations in your work and propose follow up studies which could help overcome these limitations.
- Defend your research strategy and conclusions.

PRESENTATION STANDARDS

General format and language

The thesis must use the following standards:

- The required paper format is model A4 (210 mm X 297 mm, or 8/5 X 11 in.).
- The paper version must be bound.
- Margins must be 2.5 cm for all boarders.
- The text must be 1.5 spaced, in 11-point Arial font. Footnotes should be single-spaced and in a smaller font (10-point Arial font,).

The thesis must be written in English. If you use a survey or an interview guide in another language than English, please include the translation of the survey or guide. You may cite non-English sources in your literature review or elsewhere in the thesis, but be sure to cite them properly in the bibliography.

Title Page

The title page should include the name of the author of the thesis, the study program, and the name of the thesis supervisor. The title could be the same or similar to your research question, but it does not have to be. Nevertheless, the title should give a good idea of what the thesis is about. The title should be short (less than 15 words) and easy to understand so avoid using technical terms.

The abstract

The abstract summarizes or synthesizes the contents of the thesis and must be understandable

independently from the thesis. The abstract is written in the past or the present, not the future: **it is NOT an introduction.** The abstract should be short: no more than 250 words. It should contain the main points of the thesis.

Specifically, the abstract answers the following questions:

- What is the research question?
- What are the relevant theory/theories used to explore your topic?
- How did you collect and analyze your data?
- What are your main results and recommendations?

The table of contents

The table of contents is situated just before the introduction. It states the titles of the various sections, chapters and sub-chapters and refers to pages in the thesis.

To create the table of contents, we strongly recommend that you use the specific Word function "Index and Tables" in the "Insert" menu. This will save you a lot of time!

A table of illustrations should also be included.

Introduction

The introduction is where you:

- Justify why your topic is important
- Define the main terms that you use (in particular those appearing in the title of thethesis);
- Present the authors and theories that you have chosen to apply;
- Briefly outline the empirical study you have conducted and your methodological choices;
- Present the organization of the thesis as a whole (preview of the thesis structure).

Your introduction may repeat information already stated in your abstract but can elaborate more on why the topic is an important one as well as give us the structure of your thesis.

Literature review

The literature review is an analysis and summary, **minimum 10 pages long**, that describes the academic research already done on your topic. The literature review should therefore rely principally on academic journal articles. A good literature review is typically around 20 pages and relies on around 20 sources.

Specifically, the literature review is where you:

- Discuss theories explaining the phenomenon you want to study
- Identify points of convergence and contradictions in the existing body of literature

Research question

At the end of the literature review, you will have narrowed down your topic focus such that you can form a research question. The thesis does not consist in covering a topic in general but rather in building an analysis around a question. It must be formulated simply and clearly, i.e. it must be understandable even to a non-specialist in the field.

The question selected must not be too “broad” or generic. For example, “block chain,” “cloud computing,” “social responsibility of Fintech companies” or “risk control” are not research questions. In fact, they are broad research topics.

A research question is generally presented in the form of a question to which you can attempt to reply, but the answer must not appear trivial or self-evident. Good examples would be:

What is the influence of asset-based security on risk of the financial system?

How do traditional financial companies upgrade their cloud computing systems?

Subject under empirical investigation

This section is optional but is relevant if you are focusing on a particular company(ies), sector(s). It would be here rather than in the literature review where you would provide more information about the context you are collecting your data around. For example, if I did a case study on WeBank, I would briefly describe the company here. If I did a case study on the Securities Regulatory Commission sector, I would describe that sector briefly here.

Methodology

The methodology chapter presents and justifies all of your methodological choices. You should describe your research design, your sampling method, your data collection method and your data analysis method. You must be clear on whom/what you have collected your data from including number of participants if relevant. You should not only describe your data collection method, such as survey, but also your research approach and design. For example, is your work exploratory or explanatory? Qualitative or quantitative? Is it a case study, an experiment, a cross sectional design, a longitudinal design, a technical development, or an empirical analysis? You should also attempt to justify your research strategy in discussing the strengths and weaknesses of your approach. If you have used a survey or interview guide, you should include it here.

Data Results and analysis

You must display your data in a way that the reader can easily and quickly understand. Quantitative data should be presented in table or graphic form to ensure transparency. Be mindful of your choice of graphic representation and be sure to clearly label all x and y axes. If doing qualitative research, you should include quotes or key ideas from your participants to justify your thematic analysis. You may want to display quotes or key ideas in table form before discussing your themes in depth in paragraph form.

Conclusion

You should discuss here your main findings, your recommendations, your limitations, and any ideas for follow up research. The conclusion should not simply repeat what is in your data results and analysis section but should draw broad or important conclusions. You may want to tell us whether your conclusions support or diverge from the research in your literature review. Are you able to add anything new to the theories you based your work on? Do you improve the methodologies that are currently used for your research question? Your recommendations to the relevant stakeholders of your work (managers, the government, NGOs, etc.) should clearly be connected to your data collection and not simply “good ideas” you thought of along the way. Recommendations should be detailed rather than general. For example, don’t just say “traditional financial companies should use new technologies.” Tell us how they should do that based on your data results. We do not expect your research to be perfect, but we do expect you to understand any problems in how your data was collected. In your limitations, you should clearly identify anything that might have biased your data or conclusions. Finally, you should propose ideas for follow up research to build off of, confirm, or clarify your findings.

Bibliography

Note: All articles, books, conferences, reports, courses, films, magazines, websites, etc. mentioned in the thesis text must appear in the bibliography AND your bibliography must contain uniquely the references that you mentioned or cited in your text. You should not include sources you read but did not mention in your thesis.

- The bibliography is arranged in alphabetical order by author's last name;

We strongly recommend you to use Zotero (a free bibliographic management tool) from the start to collect and organize your sources.

In general, be wary of information you find on the internet: it may be unreliable and the source is often difficult to establish.

Appendices

You are not required to have this section though it may be helpful depending on your work. Appendices are placed at the very end of your thesis, and this section does not count towards the total page length. Appendices may include any relevant materials to your thesis that are not necessary for the main body. For example, you may want to include transcripts from interviews or screen shots of surveys as they appear to participants. Long mathematical proof or code could also be included in this part. In particular, if you have a survey or interview guide in a language other than English, you should include these in their original language here.

Footnotes

In general, you should avoid the use of footnotes. Use footnotes when you want to clarify an idea without interrupting or impeding the flow of your line of thought in the main body.

Checklist of thesis contents

Section	Typical Number of Pages
Title page	1
Acknowledgements (optional)	1
Abstract	1 (no more than 250 words on a page alone)
Table of contents including illustrations (graphs, diagrams, tables, etc.) and appendices if needed	1-2
Introduction	1-2
Literature review	10-25 (minimum of 10 pages)
Presentation of the subject of empirical investigation selected (company, sector, etc.): main characteristics and rationale for this choice	1-5 (optional)
Methodology	2-5
Results and analysis	5-10
Conclusion	5-10
Bibliography	3-5
Appendices	Unlimited (optional and does not count towards page length)

Note: the number of pages in each section is to give you an idea of the length. However, in total, your literature review should be a minimum of **10 pages**, and your thesis should be a minimum of **50 pages** without appendices (in Arial 11-point font, 1.5 spaced).

RESEARCH INTEGRITY

Plagiarism

There are two types of citations:

- Direct citations (the exact text from an author is quoted in quotation marks)
- Indirect citations (an author's ideas are summarized without using their exact words)

In both cases, you need proper citation. In addition to the author's last name and date of publication, direct citations need the page number of the quote.

All forms of plagiarism are strictly prohibited. Students must submit an electronic copy of their thesis which will be analyzed with plagiarism software. In case of clear plagiarism, the program director will decide on a sanction that may range up to a mark of zero for the thesis (with no possibility of a make-up) and indefinite suspension from the program.

Confidentiality and anonymity

You must respect your participant's privacy whether it is the privacy of a person or organization. Participants should be anonymous when possible meaning no identifying information is collected. This is particularly relevant for surveys. If identifying information is collected, such as during a qualitative interview, the information should be minimized in the thesis so as to keep the participant's information confidential. It is advised to not include the participant's name anywhere in your thesis even if the participant gives you their permission.

Especially if you are using data from a particular company, they may wish you to keep that data confidential. In this case, please contact the Financial Technology & Risk Control program staff in order to obtain the necessary confidentiality contract from the school which will be signed and respected by all relevantparties.

Data Records

You have to keep records for the next two years following your thesis defense including all data related to the field work (mails of people connected, records of interviews, written agreements of participation to your study, copies of the online version of potential questionnaire as well as of the database…). All this information will allow you to prove in case of a problem the veracity of your methodology and will give you proof of the field work and of the data collection.

DATES AND CONDITIONS FOR THESIS DEFENCE

Length requirements

Your literature review should be a minimum of 10 pages, and your final thesis report should be a minimum of 50 pages. Anything less than this, and you risk receiving an automatic zero for your work.

Submitting your thesis

You must submit:

- Two copies in **bounded** paper format to the Financial Technology & Risk Control program staff:
- One copy deposited in electronic format on Blackboard.

Only documents that comply with the required format will be accepted.

Submission dates for students

Deadline	Work Submitted
November 13, 2026	Thesis Proposal
Mid December, 2026	Proposal oral defense
January 15, 2027	Literature Review & Initial Methodology
March 19, 2027	First draft of thesis report
April 23, 2027	Final thesis report
Mid May, 2027	Oral Defense

*Work should be submitted by the end of the day French time on Blackboard.

Evaluation

The thesis is worth 30 credits in total:

- 70% for the written work (graded by the thesis supervisor out of which 20% is the literature review, the grade for the final report will be validated by the reporter for your thesis defense)
- 30% for the defense (graded by the jury)

Written thesis

Your thesis supervisor will grade your thesis. The quality of the discussions you have had with your thesis supervisor and your ability to take their comments into account are therefore essential!

For information purposes, here is a qualitative marking scale:

16/20 or higher: Excellent thesis, including remarkable analyses and syntheses. It provides an original and personal approach to the research question, in terms of both the understanding of the theoretical issues and the recommendations.

In addition, the thesis follows all the guidelines completely: it is written clearly and its form is beyond reproach. The problem is interesting and clearly presented. The review of the literature is complete and illustrates an in-depth understanding of the theoretical issues related to the research question. The empirical section rests on rigorous methods, and methodological choices are justified well. The theoretical framework is applied effectively to provide a framework for the results of the empirical analysis.

14-15/20: Very good thesis, marked by good writing, analyses and syntheses. The work performed is significant and illustrates a true personal investment. The thesis meets the specifications completely (see above), but does not represent an original contribution.

12-13/20: Good thesis. Generally abides by the specifications and contains analyses and syntheses but also a few shortcomings. For example: the literature review may be incomplete, the methodology could have been described and justified in greater detail, etc. The personal investment made is acceptable, but could have been greater.

10-11/20: Acceptable thesis. It abides by certain aspects of the guidelines but also has notable gaps: the form is not meticulous, certain references cited in the literature review were poorly understood, the methodology lacks rigor and/or is not justified, theoretical references used are not always pertinent, the bibliography is incomplete, etc. Overall, the personal investment in the thesis is low.

Less than 10/20: Inadequate thesis, which overall does not abide by the guidelines. For example: there is no bibliography, some portions or paragraphs are incomprehensible, and the thesis does not answer the question raised or overlooks an essential dimension of the problem. The personal investment made is insufficient and reflects poor use of resources. If your written work is inadequate (less than 10/20), you will not be allowed to present your thesis orally in front of the jury.

Credits are assigned as follows:

Mark	Credits
10/20 or more	30 credits
Under 10/20	0 credit

Oral defense

Thesis defense will take place at Audencia Shenzhen campus. The jury is made up of at least two professors, including your thesis supervisor and other reporter(s).

The defense of the thesis proposal lasts 15 minutes and is broken down as follows:

- Presentation of proposal: 5 minutes
- Comments and questions from the jury: 5 minutes
- Deliberation: 2 minutes
- Feedback from the jury: 3 minutes.

If your thesis proposal fail to pass the jury's quality requirement, you may be required to conduct a major revision or change the thesis topic.

The defense of the final thesis report lasts 30 minutes and is broken down as follows:

- Presentation of the results of your research: 10 minutes
- Comments and questions from the jury: 10 minutes
- Deliberation: 5 minutes
- Feedback from the jury: 5 minutes.

You can only present your final thesis orally in front of the jury if you have submitted all required work (proposal, literature review and final report) and if your final report has been graded 10/20 or above.

The defense mark is determined by the jury. It mainly takes into account two criteria:

- Your capacity to clearly present your work, the approach and the contributions – theoretical

and practical – of your thesis;
- The quality of your answers to the questions asked by the jury.

During a 10-minute presentation, you must therefore:

- Review the question that you have chosen to analyze and demonstrate its merits,
- Review and justify the methodological approach you have selected,
- Present your results, conclusions, recommendations, and limitations,
- Explain briefly how the thesis has helped you with your careergoals.

Don't forget that the jury has read your thesis and prepared questions.

For information purposes, here is the qualitative marking scale:

16/20 or higher: Excellent defense. The presentation is perfectly clear and well structured. The oral communication is of high quality. The results and recommendations are well developed and put into perspective, and effectively synthesize the contents of the thesis. The defense provides new insights into the thesis and/or anticipates certain questions by the jury. The answers to the jury's questions are clear and convincing.

12/20 to 15/20: Good defense, clear and well structured. The oral communication is good, and the allotted time is respected. However, some aspects of the thesis are glossed over and/or the answers to some of the jury's questions are not entirely clear and/or satisfactory.

11/20 and under: Insufficient defense. The oral presentation is not clear and structured enough, or simply repeats word for word what appears in the introduction or the abstract. The results of the thesis are not developed or put into perspective. The answers to the jury's questions are not convincing.

Prize for the best thesis

Each year, a jury supervised by the Financial Technology & Risk Control program director selects the best thesis produced as part of the Financial Technology & Risk Control program. A certificate will be given for this prize. The jury is not obliged to award a prize if the quality of the thesis submitted does not warrant this distinction.

Appendix 1 LITERATURE REVIEW Grading Grid

	Unsatisfactory (0-1 Points) Does not meet expectations	Satisfactory (2 Points) Meets minimal expectations	Good (3 Points) Above minimal expectations	Exceptional (4 Points) At a level which is in addition to what is needed for "good"
Research Question				
Selection and Analysis of the Literature				
Writing Style				
Citation and Bibliography				
***Initial Research Methodology**				
				Total Points____/20

* For the initial research methodology, the student must identify: 1) a research design (e.g. case study, cross-sectional study, longitudinal study, experiment, empirical study, etc.), 2) a method (e.g. survey, interviews, regression, machine learning, mathematical derivation etc.) 3) sampling approach (e.g. convenience, snow-ball method, stratified sampling, etc.).

The student at this point does not need to elaborate the details of their research method such as what questions they will ask participants if they do a survey or how they will analyze their data.

The student should be directed to the course textbook to help them.

Grading Grid Explanation

	Unsatisfactory (0-1 Points) Does not meet expectations	Satisfactory (2 Points) Meets minimal expectations	Good (3 Points) Above minimal expectations	Exceptional (4 Points) At a level which is in addition to what is needed for "good"
Research Question	• RQ is unclear and/or not feasible	• RQ may need some additional work to help clarify and/or be more feasible	• RQ is clear and feasible	• *In addition…* • RQ addresses a novel area of research, addressing a gap in the literature and/or addressing a real business problem (i.e. student has approached a company, and the thesis is part of a consulting project)
Selection and Analysis of the Literature	• Sources are mostly non-academic (newspapers, websites, etc.)	• Uses mostly academic sources **but** • The focus/relevance of the literature may be unclear ***and/or*** • The review may be more of a summary than a synthesis	• Uses mostly academic sources which are relevant and has a clear focus • Able to synthesize rather than summarize • Interprets the literature and critically reviews (e.g. identifies gaps, flaws, conflicting studies, etc. in the research)	• *In addition…* • Explores in depth theoretical approaches reaching their own conclusions and may develop their own theoretical framework using components of the literature
Writing Style	• Contains numerous editing mistakes (grammar/ spelling/ syntax) making the writing difficult to understand **and/or** • Structure and arrangement of literature unclear	• May need additional work on structure and arrangement of literature **and/or** • Creating a clear introduction, conclusion, and transitions • Ideas often not clearly explained or developed	• Has a logical structure and arrangement of literature **and** • Has a clear introduction, conclusion, and transitions • Some ideas may not be clearly explained or need more development	• *In addition…* • All ideas fully and clearly explained, writing contains few mistakes
Citation and Bibliography	• Contains numerous in text citation mistakes (for example not including page numbers for direct quotes, including author's first name, etc.) **and/or** • Contains plagiarism **and/or** • Bibliography is missing numerous sources and/or contains	• Contains some mistakes for in text citation and bibliography entries	• In text citation and bibliography mostly correct	• *In addition…* • All in text citation and bibliography entries correct

	sources which don't appear in the text **and/or** • Bibliography is incorrectly formatted (for example not in alphabetical order)			
Initial Research Methodology	• Fails to identify 1) research design 2) method **or** 3) sampling approach	• Identifies all 3 components **but** • They may not be appropriate for the RQ **and/or** • Fails to justify choice or cite appropriate sources	• Identifies all 3 components which are appropriate for the RQ **but** • May need more work on justifying their choices **or** citing appropriate sources	• *In addition…* • Clearly justifies all of their choices (e.g. chooses qualitative interviews because sample population is small or difficult to reach) • Frequently cites appropriate sources (e.g. if the student chooses a case study they cite Yin)

Appendix 2: THESIS REPORT Grading Grid

Final thesis report Grading Grid

	Unsatisfactory (0-1 Points) Does not meet expectations	Satisfactory (2 Points) Meets minimal expectations	Good (3 Points) Above minimal expectations	Exceptional (4 Points) At a level which is in addition to what is needed for "good"
Research Question & Literature Review (nb: citation graded in Presentation)				
Research Design				
Analysis				
Conclusion (implications, recommendations& limitations)				
Presentation (citation, format, writing style)				
				Total Points____/20

Grading Grid Explanation

	Unsatisfactory (0-1 Points) Does not meet expectations	Satisfactory (2 Points) Meets minimal expectations	Good (3 Points) Above minimal expectations	Exceptional (4 Points) At a level which is in addition to what is needed for "good"
Research Question & Literature Review (nb: citation graded in Presentation)	• RQ is unclear **and/or** • LR undeveloped, little to no revision based on feedback	• RQ may need some additional work to help clarify **and/or** • LR minimally developed & fails to adequately take into account feedback	• RQ is clear **and/or** • LR developed and takes into account feedback	• *In addition…* • RQ addresses a novel area of research, addressing a gap in the literature and/or addressing a real business problem **and/or** • LR well developed and takes into account feedback
Research Design	• Does not connect to RQ **and/or** • May be missing components **and/or** • Incorrectly describes the research design	• Minimally connects to RQ **and/or** • Sufficiently explains research design but could use more description **and/or** • Incorrectly describes some components	• Clearly connects to RQ • Clearly explains research design • May need more work justifying their approach and/or citing supporting sources	• *In addition…* • Justifies their approach and cites supporting sources
Results & Analysis	• Results are displayed in a way that is unclear **and/or** • Analysis contains numerous errors	• There are some problems with the way results are displayed **and/or** • Analysis contains some errors	• Results are displayed in a logical way • Analysis and results contain few to no errors	• *In addition…* • • Analysis is well developed with logically determined conclusions
Conclusion	• Does not adequately address • 1) implications, • 2) recommendations, 3) and limitations	• Adequately addresses at least two	• Adequately addresses all three	• All three are well developed • Includes ideas for follow up studies
Presentation	• Numerous citation errors and/or problems with the bibliography **and/or**	• Some citation errors and/or some problems with the bibliography	• Few citation errors and/or problems with the bibliography • Few formatting problems	• *In addition…* • The work is of an exceptional level of quality

	• Formatting inconsistent or inadequate (no page numbers, no headings, use of multiple fonts, etc.) **and/or** • Writing isn't clear, contains grammar/spelling mistakes making it difficult to understand, no transitions or clear structure	• Some formatting problems • Main idea somewhat developed • Logic of thesis somewhat clear and easy to follow • Writing is somewhat clear and easy to understand	• Main idea overall clearly developed • Logic of thesis overall clear and easy to follow • Writing is overall clear and easy to understand	

Appendix 3: ORAL DEFENSE Grading Grid

DEFENSE		
	Grade	Out of
Form Are the slides adequate and well presented? Is the presentation dynamic? Is the timing well respected?		6 Points
Content Clarity of the presentation Is the project properly defined and presented? Is the presenter capable of being concise?		6 Points
Answers to questions Does the presenter give accurate and coherent answers? Does the presenter show critical self-reflection?		8 Points
TOTAL		20 points